

Building a Project and Portfolio Office at NFU Mutual

How a centralised PMO gave a regulated financial-services business clearer governance, a single view of its portfolio and better use of its people.

Role	Environment	Portfolio	Remit
Project & Portfolio Office Manager	Regulated financial services	Technology, business change, compliance	Governance, finance, people

Overview

As Project & Portfolio Office Manager at NFU Mutual, I was responsible for establishing and leading a centralised PMO function.

The aim was to strengthen delivery governance, give leaders better visibility of the portfolio and optimise resources across multiple business and technology programmes.

The context

NFU Mutual operates in a regulated financial-services environment. The role called for strategic oversight, disciplined planning and stakeholder alignment across diverse delivery teams.

Establishing the service and governance framework

I started by assessing the existing project-delivery landscape, then designed a fit-for-purpose PMO framework to support NFU Mutual's transformation objectives.

Key activities

- Conducted a full PMO service review and maturity assessment.
- Defined governance standards, reporting cadence and assurance processes.
- Implemented portfolio-level dashboards showing progress, risk and spend.
- Introduced standardised templates for project initiation, planning and closure.
- Embedded quality-assurance checkpoints across the delivery lifecycle.

The result was a structured, transparent governance model that improved decision-making and delivery predictability.

Portfolio management and delivery oversight

I led the portfolio management function, keeping strategic priorities aligned with operational execution across technology, business change and compliance initiatives.

Responsibilities

- Portfolio planning, prioritisation and resource allocation.
- Tracking delivery performance against KPIs and milestones.
- Managing dependencies and cross-programme risks.
- Facilitating executive portfolio reviews and investment decisions.
- Coordinating with business units and IT delivery teams.

This gave NFU Mutual a consolidated view of delivery health and investment performance.

Financial and resource management

I managed financial governance and resource planning for the portfolio, so that every workstream was cost-efficient and accountable.

Key achievements

- Established cost-tracking and forecasting mechanisms.
- Managed the PMO budget and vendor contracts.
- Introduced resource-capacity planning tools.
- Supported commercial negotiations and service-level adherence.

This financial discipline reinforced transparency and value realisation across the portfolio.

Leadership and stakeholder engagement

As PMO lead, I built and managed a high-performing team and encouraged collaboration and continuous improvement.

Focus areas

- Team leadership and mentoring.
- Capability development and performance management.
- Stakeholder engagement across business and IT leadership.
- Embedding a culture of delivery excellence and accountability.

The PMO became a trusted partner to senior stakeholders, providing clarity, control and confidence in delivery outcomes.

Strategic impact

The engagement delivered a mature, commercially aware PMO service that strengthened NFU Mutual's ability to manage complex portfolios and deliver strategic change effectively.

It enhanced governance, improved delivery assurance and established a sustainable framework for future transformation initiatives.